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Epistemological Disenfranchisement in the Humanitarian Sector

How Global North Metrics Marginalize Indigenous Knowledge Management

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Abstract

This thesis investigates the friction between reporting metrics derived from the Global North and Indigenous Knowledge Management (IKM) through an institutional ethnography of Cruz Vermelha de Timor-Leste (CVTL), the Red Cross National Society in Timor-Leste.

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Acknowledgements

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Key Concepts

Accountability to Affected Populations: The commitment of humanitarian actors to be answerable to the people they serve, ensuring that communities have a voice in decisions affecting them and can provide feedback or lodge complaints.

Do No Harm: A foundational principle requiring that interventions — including technological ones — must not cause unintended harm to affected populations. Derived from medical ethics and formalised in humanitarian practice.

Humanitarian Principles: The four core principles guiding humanitarian action: humanity, neutrality, impartiality, and independence. Established by the International Committee of the Red Cross and endorsed by the United Nations.

1 Introduction

Cruz Vermelha de Timor-Leste (CVTL) is a National Society of the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC). It operates in a post-colonial context, where the legacy of Portuguese colonization as well as the subsequent invasion and genocide committed by Indonesian forces has shaped the socio-political landscape. As an auxiliary to the government, the organization's work encompasses a range of humanitarian and development activities, including disaster response, health services, and community development. CVTL currently faces a persistent communication chasm where formal reporting metrics demanded by international donors and the IFRC differ from practices preferred by local staff and volunteers. International organizations, like the IFRC, are institutions with structures of behavior and practice that are expected to be followed by their partners and National Societies, like CVTL.

It seems, however, that the behaviors and practices that are being demanded by the funding bodies and international partners seem not to align with the preferred practices of the local staff at CVTL. Lack of reporting is, of course, a significant concern for the donors. The reporting metrics demanded by donors and the IFRC are standardized across the humanitarian sector and are designed to create accountability and demonstrate effectiveness. Lack of adherence to the reporting requirements can lead to loss of funding and resources, which can have serious consequences for the organization's ability to carry out its humanitarian work. The disconnect between the reporting metrics and the practices of local staff can also lead to a lack of trust and credibility with donors, which can further jeopardize funding and resources. This misalignment between demands and practices may be an anomaly to CVTL, but it is also very possible that this is an issue that is widespread across the humanitarian sector, particularly for organizations operating in post-colonial contexts with strong oral traditions and different ways of sharing knowledge. The purpose of this thesis is to investigate whether CVTL's lack of adherence to the standardized reporting metrics is a localized organizational issue or if it is symptomatic of a wider structural incongruence between preferred practices of humanitarian workers from the working contexts and that of global humanitarian structures of project cycle management.

1.1 Surviving in the system

The humanitarian sector operates with a fundamental tension between local autonomy and standardization—derived from and imposed by Global North institutions—in the name of accountability. For organizations like CVTL, this tension manifests in the need to navigate the demands of international donor bodies while also maintaining their own practices and priorities that are rooted in local contexts and cultures. In order to enjoy the confidence of its donors, CVTL must demonstrate its effectiveness and accountability to them while also ensuring that its work remains relevant and responsive to the needs of the communities it serves. The adoption of reporting metrics of their donors and the Federation can be seen as a strategy for CVTL to survive and thrive within the international humanitarian system as it allows access to funding and resources that are essential for their operations.

This strategy, however, also comes with risks as it may lead to a misalignment between the preferred practices of the local staff and the practices demanded by donors. Technical upgrades, such as the implementation of digital reporting systems, are often seen as a solution to these challenges but they may not actually address the underlying issues of structural incongruence. Local practitioners may find themselves navigating a complex web of reporting requirements that do not align with their preferred ways of sharing knowledge or value the information they deem important, leading to frustration and a sense of disempowerment. The rigid, “ordered” reporting systems are demanded by the international institutions and donors that supply the funding to partner organizations in the Global South and are standardized across the humanitarian sector in an effort to professionalize the sector and create accountability. The problem is that these systems are not context-based and instead impose a one-size-fits-all approach to knowledge management that may not be suitable for all organizations, particularly those operating in post-colonial contexts with strong oral traditions. Local humanitarian workers may find themselves becoming “custodians of comprehension”(Johar, 2025) —bureaucrats tallying the numbers and filling out the forms to satisfy donor requirements—rather than “catalysts for transformation”(Johar, 2025) —practitioners who are able to use their local knowledge and expertise to drive meaningful change in their communities. And so, partner organizations in the Global South, like CVTL, and their staff are left to negotiate their legitimacy within the system while navigating the power dynamics in which they are dependent on the funding and resources provided by the Global North institutions and donors.

1.2 Problem Statement

The data that is being reported and the information that is not are both important to understand the dynamics of knowledge production and power in the humanitarian sector. By examining the case of CVTL, this thesis seeks to shed light on the broader dynamics of knowledge production and power in the humanitarian sector and to contribute to ongoing discussions about decolonizing humanitarianism and valuing diverse forms of knowledge.

1.3 Research Question

The research aims to answer the following research question:

How does the “culture of comprehension”(Katsamangos, 2025) —the bureaucratic demand for ordered, standardized reporting metrics— function as a mechanism of communicative disenfranchisement for local humanitarian workers in the Global South and in what ways do these actors navigate the tension between local knowledge management practices and the demands of international donors?

1.3.1 Study Objectives

1. How do CVTL staff perceive the effectiveness of mandated digital reporting tools?

2. How do current reporting mechanisms impose an “ordered bias” that forces complex, context-specific knowledge into rigid, standardized formats?
3. How do local leaders within organizations navigate the tension between the demands of international donors and the compulsions of local knowledge management practices?

1.4 Methodology

This research utilizes a qualitative case study to investigate the communicative processes that shape knowledge management within CVTL, serving as an entry point to analyze the broader “documentary reality” (Smith, 1990 cited in (Escobar, 1995), p. 107) created by donor institutions in the humanitarian sector. The mixed-method research will involve a combination of participant observation, semi-structured interviews, and document analysis to gather data on the experiences and perspectives of local humanitarian workers at CVTL. Document analysis will review institutional guidelines and reports, as well as digital tools (e.g., KoboToolbox) used for reporting, in order to understand the formal structures and expectations around knowledge management and reporting. Data analysis will be conducted using thematic analysis to identify key themes and patterns in the data. The conceptual structures for this thesis concern decolonial theory (Dorothy Smith, Arturo Escobar, Paul Sillitoe, Alan Bicker, and Johan Pottier), the Theory of Communicative Disenfranchisement (Elizabeth A. Hintz and Kristina M. Sharp), and the Cynefin framework (Dave Snowden and Alessandro Rancati) to analyze the dynamics of knowledge production and power in the humanitarian sector.

1.4.1 Ethical Considerations

This study adheres to the UCD Low Risk Study protocols, ensuring that research is conducted with respect for the dignity of participants and without causing intentional harm.

- **Informed and Voluntary Consent:** All participants are fully briefed on the study’s purpose and provided written consent forms. They are informed of their right to withdraw at any time without penalty.
- **Confidentiality and Anonymity:** To encourage honesty and protect professional standing, all data is anonymized.
- **Data Sovereignty and Management:** Research is conducted in alignment with CVTL and IFRC data-sharing policies, with data stored securely according to university guidelines and accessible only to the research team.
- **Positionality and Bias:** The researcher acknowledges her positionality as an outsider to the local context and takes steps to mitigate bias through reflexivity and by prioritizing voices of local practitioners and perspectives from the Global South. The researcher also acknowledges the power dynamics inherent in the research process and strives to conduct the research in a way that is respectful to the participants. The researcher is also conscientious of the post-colonial context in Timor-Leste and her positionality as a person of Indonesian descent and a national of the United States of America—countries

that bear responsibility for the genocide in Timor-Leste and its continued impact—and took care to approach the research with sensitivity.

1.4.2 Utility & Limitations

The research aims not only to produce academic knowledge but to offer practical insights that can inform the practices of CVTL and the wider humanitarian community. The findings will be shared with CVTL in order to contribute to their efforts in capacity building within the organization. The research also aims to contribute to ongoing discussions about improving knowledge management practices and addressing communicative disenfranchisement in the humanitarian sector.

The limitations of this research include the potential for bias in the data collection and analysis process, as well as the limited generalizability of the findings due to the focus on a single case study, that of CVTL. Additionally, the research may be limited by the availability and willingness of participants to share their experiences and perspectives, as well as by the constraints of time and resources. The researcher will take steps to mitigate these limitations through careful data collection and analysis, as well as by being transparent about the limitations of the study in the final report.

2 Literature Review

This literature review synthesizes existing research on the intersection of humanitarianism and development work, decolonial theory, and philosophical inquiries of knowledge itself. The review is structured around three main themes:

1. the bureaucratization of information through standardized reporting mechanisms,
2. the disenfranchisement of local humanitarian workers in knowledge production, and
3. how these humanitarians navigate the tension between the demand for standardized reporting and the complexity of their lived experiences.

2.1 Strategy

2.2 Key terms and concepts

2.3 Conceptual frameworks

The Cynefin Framework was “designed to manage anthro-complexity, or complexity in human systems” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 57). Limitations of the framework include its focus on organizational decision-making and its potential oversimplification of complex social phenomena. However, it provides a useful lens for understanding the challenges of knowledge management in humanitarian contexts. Methodologically, because the Cynefin framework is utilized as a “decision support framework” rather than a predictive model, the findings are intended to offer diagnostic perspective and “sense-making” rather than “context-free” or “standard solutions” (Cynefin.io, 2023). Another limitation is that as participants reflect on past reporting challenges, the data is subject to the risk of retrospective coherence, where individuals may inadvertently reframe their original state of “aporetic” confusion into a more structured and logical narrative that masks the initial complexity of the experience (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 61). Finally, the findings must be viewed through the lens of “bounded applicability,” recognizing that the insights derived from this case study may not be universally generalizable but can offer valuable perspectives for similar contexts and contribute to broader theoretical discussions in the field of humanitarian knowledge management (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 60).

2.3.1 Bureaucratization of Information

In their chapter ‘Evaluation and the White Gaze in International Development’, authors Sadaf Shallwani and Shama Dossa boldly claim:

“The White gaze shapes how issues are conceptualized, understood and measured by establishing Whiteness as the norm and the White Western world as the centre of legitimate knowledge. The White gaze focuses on perceived deficits in Brown and Black people and defines success and how it can be measured. The White gaze further determines what is

considered valid knowledge and valid evidence through the technocratization of the field of evaluation and its methods.”

— (Shallwani and Dossa, 2023) [p. 52]

In Arturo Escobar’s seminal work, “Encountering Development: The Making and Unmaking of the Third World”, he asks his reader not to “overlook the ways in which development operates as an arena of cultural contestation and identity construction” (Escobar, 1995, p. 15). Western sense-making has not only shaped the way that development and humanitarian aid are conceptualized, but also how they are evaluated and measured (Escobar, 1995, p. 15). The “problematization of poverty” that has been central to the development project is also central to the humanitarian system, where affected communities are framed as problems to be solved and data to be measured (Escobar, 1995, p. 17). And so, the “professionalization of development knowledge and the institutionalization of development practices” was a key aspect of ‘solving’ the problem irrespective of context and conditions (Escobar, 1995, p. 17). The humanitarian system has inherited this legacy of Western sense-making, shaped by colonial capitalist constructions of ‘developed’ and ‘underdeveloped’, ‘First World’ and ‘Third World’, and it is from “this privileged space that economics pervaded the entire practice of development” (Escobar, 1995, p. 18). The so-called “rational techniques—planning, methods of measurement and assesment, professional knowledges, institutional practices, and the like— organizes both forms of knowledge and types of power, relating one to the other, in the construction and treatment” of humanitarian and development issues (Escobar, 1995, p. 18).

This bureaucratization of information can lead to a disconnect between the lived experiences of local humanitarian workers and the information that is being reported to donors, which can ultimately impact the effectiveness of humanitarian interventions not only through reduced responsiveness but also by undermining the trust between the local humanitarian workers and the communities they serve.

2.3.2 Disenfranchisement of Local Humanitarian Workers in Knowledge Production

“This regime of order and truth is a quintessential aspect of modernity and has been deepened by economics and development. It is reflected in an objectivist and empiricist stand that dictates that the Third World and its peoples exist ‘out there,’ to be known through theories and intervened upon from the outside.”

— (Escobar, 1995, p. 8)

In his article “Goal-Coded Systems and the Crisis of Orientation”, professor Indy Johar, co-founder of Dark Matter Labs, identifies the nuances that differentiate agency from orientation. Although Johar writes with a focus on Artificial Intelligence, his insights are applicable to the humanitarian sector and its systems of standardization. Furthermore, Dark Matter is a non-profit “field laboratory” analyzing “the shifts required in the underlying ‘dark matter’—monetary, economic, governance, regulatory and policy systems—to manifest transformations... towards

a future of mutual thriving” and has a history of working with governments and INGOs (Future Observatory, no date). Johar argues that “goal-coded systems”—systems that are designed to achieve specific goals—can lead to a “crisis of orientation” for the users (Johar, 2026). In this case, the users being humanitarian workers in the Global South who are required to navigate these systems. The “goal-coded systems” and “their operative purpose arrives from outside. They are prompted, instructed, rewarded, benchmarked, fine-tuned, evaluated, constrained, deployed and corrected by external frames” (Johar, 2026). The external frame, here, being the donor institutions and the wider humanitarian system that is structured around the requirements and expectations of these donors. It must be asked: What type of information is being valued and what is being left out? Who determines the value? Who “produces knowledge about the Third World” and “from what spaces”? [Chandra Mohanty as referenced in (Escobar, 1995, p. 8)]

Diane Doane, author of “The INGO Problem: Privelege, power, and renewal”, explains that one current role of INGOs is to function as intermediaries between larger donors (traditional funders like governments) and the humanitarian organizations to be funded (Doane, 2024, p. 66). More often than not, the donors and INGOs are based in the Global North—the governments of European and North American countries, large institutions and organizations like the United Nations, the IFRC, Save the Children, etc.—while the humanitarian organizations that they fund are based in the Global South—community-based organizations, local NGOs, national branches of INGOs, etc. In the name of accountability and transparency, the INGOs manage not only the money funneled to local organizations but the information moving upwards to donors, as well. Many critics of the sector have pointed to this structure as a key flaw of what they deem the “Humanitarian Industrial Complex” (“Interviewee Funder,” 2026). Even actors within this system, like former CEO of Oxfam GB, Danny Sriskandarajah, have called out the “political economy based on the trickle-down approach” as “the heart of our business model” (Doane, 2024, p. 66).

And so with billions of dollars flowing through this system, INGOs have a vested interest in maintaining their cut of the pie justified through narratives around trust, accountability, and transparency. There is an assumed mistrust of local organizations and their inability to manage funds and information, which is used to justify the need for INGOs to act as intermediaries and gatekeepers of knowledge production and finances (Doane, 2024, p. 10). And so based on this narrative, there must be oversight. Who is assumed to be trustworthy? The INGOs based in the Global North. What results is paternalism fueled by a legacy of colonial power dynamics [Chandra Mohanty as referenced in (Escobar, 1995, p. 9)]. Utilizing the Cynefin framework to “map the landscape of experiences”, one identifies the Global North as the “holder of the solution” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37) in the current structure of the humanitarian system with the Global South positioned as a problem to be solved.

The “predominant strategic function” of this colonial discourse “is the creation of a space for a ‘subject peoples’ through the production of knowledge in terms of which surveillance is exercised... in order to justify conquest and to establish systems of administration and instruction” [Chandra Mohanty as referenced in (Escobar, 1995, p. 9)]

This dynamic is still present in the humanitarian sector today, where the Global North continues to exert power and control over the Global South through the management of information and finances. There is still “a form of governmentality that in marking out a ‘subject nation’”—in this case the communities and local humanitarians of the Global South— in which the Global North “appropriates, directs and dominates its various spheres of activity” [Homi Bhaba as cited in (Escobar, 1995, p. 9)]. Shallwani and Dossa synthesize this very dynamic as it manifests in development work, the sister of the humanitarian sector:

“Evaluation in global development centers on the White subject as the doer, the Savior and the neutral expert. It establishes Whiteness as the norm, identifies deficits and problems in the lives of Black and Brown people and demonstrates how interventions designed and funded by the Global North are necessary and effective— thereby reinforcing the feel-good element of the White Saviorism. Furthermore, the White gaze contorts the purposes and ethics of evaluation. While couched in the discourse of ‘accountability’ and ‘evidence-based’ decision making, evaluation implicitly serves as a tool for White surveillance and intervention on Brown and Black lives in the Global South”.

— (Shallwani and Dossa, 2023) [p. 43]

Underestimation of capacity and the lack of trust granted to local humanitarians are the lasting effects of colonial capitalism, played out in what Dr. Syed Hussein Alatas deemed “The Myth of the Lazy Native”:

In its historical empirical manifestation the colonial ideology utilized the idea of the lazy native to justify compulsion and unjust practices in the mobilization of labour in the colonies. It portrayed a negative image of the natives and their society to justify and rationalize European conquest and domination of the area. It distorted elements of social and human reality to ensure a comfortable construction of the ideology.

— (Alatas, 1977, p. 2)

One would be hard-pressed to deny the eerily similar characteristics of colonial capitalism found in the humanitarian system today, particularly through:

“(a) predominant control of and access to capital by an alien economic power, (b) the control of the colony by a government run by members of the alien power, acting on its behalf, (c) the highest level of business, trade and industry, held by the alien dominating the community... (f) the organization of production around semi-free labour, (g) the absence of guilds or trade unions as a counterweight to exploitation, (h) the non-involvement of large sections of the population... and (i) the presence of a set of antitheses in the colonizes society described by the term dualism.”

— (Alatas, 1977, p. 2)

White Saviorism, while often dismissed as a problem of representation, is actually a symptom of the deeper structural issues of the humanitarian system, which are rooted in racial, colonial power dynamics. The legacy of this structure continues to influence the production of knowledge in the way that information is managed, evaluated, and reported. “Local people may have some participation in evaluation processes,” writes Doane, “but it is ultimately the assessment of a northern-based (usually) white person from the outside who determines a project’s success. Those on the ground are not, in any way, holding international actors to account” (Doane, 2024, p. 52).

2.3.3 Navigating the Tension Between Standardized Reporting and Lived Experiences

The “western-derived”, ill defined notion of ‘capacity’—a trait local humanitarians are assumed to lack—lays the foundation for paternalism through intervention and oversight by Global North institutions (Doane, 2024, p. 50). According to Doane, “most risk management and due diligence systems” of these institutions are concerned with capacity (Doane, 2024, p. 50).

“Unfortunately, the assessment of who has ‘capacity’ has been weaponized and used as means to justify the slow relinquishment of power by INGOs and their hollow promises of localization. We require more individuals actively engaged in community work and fewer confined to their desks, endlessly reporting to donors.”

— Michael Vincent Mercado, Voice and Insights Lab Team Manager at the Center for Disaster Preparedness Foundation (Doane, 2024, p. 50)

Donors hype vague concepts of ‘empowerment’ and ‘localization,’ but the extent of autonomy granted to local ‘partner’ organizations and their staff is limited by the standardized reporting mechanisms. Looking back to Johar’s thoughts on “goal-coded systems”, he argues that orientation is often overlooked:

Orientation is deeper than agency. Orientation is the formation of concern. It is the emergence of direction from within a life, a body, a history, a field of relations, a condition of vulnerability, a horizon of death and continuity. Orientation is not merely the capacity to pursue an end. It is the capacity to discover, revise and be claimed by what ends are worth pursuing.

— (Johar, 2026)

Without genuine orientation, individuals become “custodians of comprehension” rather than “catalysts for transformation” (Johar, 2025). In the humanitarian sector, this can manifest in the way that local humanitarian workers must prioritize satisfying donor requirements. These humanitarians have to spend their time filling out forms and writing reports that are designed to meet the expectations of donors rather than interacting with the communities they come from and serve.

3 Methodology

3.1 Participant Selection

The study will include:

- Local humanitarian workers at CVTL who are involved in knowledge management and reporting processes.
- Staff from CVTL’s donor organizations who interact with CVTL’s reporting and knowledge management systems.
- Representatives from other donor institutions working in both Timor-Leste and elsewhere in order to provide insights into the broader context of the donor-recipient relationship and its impact on knowledge management practices.

3.2 Data Collection

Data will be collected through a combination of qualitative and quantitative methods, including:

- Semi-structured interviews with local humanitarian workers and donor representatives to explore their experiences, perspectives, and challenges related to knowledge management and reporting.
- Document analysis of CVTL’s reporting templates, guidelines, and other relevant materials to understand the formal structures and expectations around knowledge management.

3.3 Data Analysis

Data will be analyzed using thematic analysis to identify key themes and patterns related to the research questions. The analysis will be guided by the Cynefin Framework, which provides a lens for understanding the complexity of knowledge management in humanitarian contexts, and the Theory of Communicative Disfranchisement, which offers insights into the power dynamics and marginalization of local voices in knowledge production. The findings will be interpreted with existing literature on humanitarianism, decolonial theory, and knowledge production in mind.

4 Discussion and Analysis

But with such standardization of metrics, one must ask whose stories are being told and how? What knowledge is being valued and what is being left out? What type of information can be measured?

4.1 Findings in Relation to the Study Objectives

The findings of this study will be analyzed in relation to the three main themes through the study objectives:

1. How do CVTL staff perceive the effectiveness of mandated reporting tools?
2. How do current reporting mechanisms impose an ordered bias?
3. How do local humanitarian workers navigate the tension between the demand for standardized reporting and the complexity of their lived experiences?

4.1.1 Perceptions of Mandated Reporting Tools

4.1.2 Ordered Bias in Reporting Mechanisms

4.1.3 Navigating the Tension

As it stands, not only is the information that is being reported to donors disconnected from the lived experiences of local humanitarian workers, but these workers are also disenfranchised in the knowledge production process. The standardized reporting mechanisms that are designed to satisfy donor requirements often do not take into account the local knowledge and expertise of local humanitarian workers, and instead prioritize the information that is deemed valuable by donors.

4.2 Implications for Practice

The Cynefin framework emphasizes the importance of context in decision-making and problem-solving. An element of contextual awareness is acknowledging the “need to establish meaningful processes of stakeholder engagement beyond user research to make sense of local experiences and build whole ecosystems from the bottom-up” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37). Furthermore, problem-solving through such “complexity-informed” approaches will find “the answers emerge from the same group who is researching and acting in the landscape” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37). Rather than the affected communities and their local humanitarian workers becoming data and subjects to be known and measured (Escobar, 1995), they are active participants in the process of making sense of their lived experiences and the way this information is used to inform decision-making and action. This is a shift from the traditional top-down approach to humanitarian aid, where decisions are made by external actors based on standardized data and metrics, to a more participatory and inclusive approach that values local knowledge and experiences. The current approach of “prescription and direction” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37) from funding agencies and INGOs, who rely on standardized reporting tools and metrics, continue to place external actors as “holder of the solution” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37)

with local humanitarians as instruments to be used and communities as problems to be solved, data to be measured, and subjects to be known.

There are already—and have always been—beacons of change working quietly in the sector, overshadowed by the dominant paradigms and giants of this “Humanitarian Industrial Complex” (“Interviewee Funder,” 2026). In contrast to the rigorous reporting requirements of traditional donors and INGOs, there are emerging models of funding and support that prioritize local knowledge, expertise, and power. One interviewee was the founder of a non-profit charity that provides direct funding to local humanitarian organizations in over 70 countries without the requirement of standardized reporting, instead trust is cultivated through relationship-building with these local humanitarians. This founder called out the “limousine liberals”—the industry giants that siphon off funds intended to support work in affected communities. Instead, money is allocated to the overhead costs of these Global North institutions and their staff that parachute into communities for short-term projects. This founder’s accusations are not unwarranted, in fact, the OECD has “finally acknowledged” that “giving through INGOs”— or “fund-mediaries”, as some have dubbed them— “actually costs more” than giving directly to community-based organizations (Doane, 2024, p. 61). The overspending is precisely due to the “inflated international overhead and salary costs” that the founder interviewed called out (Doane, 2024, p. 61). In fact, direct funding to local intermediaries and organizations “can deliver programming that is 32% more cost efficient than [through] international intermediaries” (Doane, 2024, p. 61). So why is money still being funneled through these intermediaries? The legacy of colonial power dynamics and the narratives of mistrust that justify the need for INGOs to act as intermediaries and gatekeepers of knowledge production continue to perpetuate this system, even in the face of evidence that it is not the most effective way to support affected communities. Doane argues that it is the responsibility of these institutions holding privilege to recognize their perpetuation of colonial, racial dynamics and to take active steps to make space for the local humanitarians and the communities served.

Grassroot, “return to culture” (Escobar, 1995, p. 14).

5 Conclusions

This thesis aims to explore these questions through a case study of CVTL with a focus on understanding how reporting metrics are shaping knowledge management practices and if this may be leading to epistemological disenfranchisement. In the humanitarian sector information carries the weight of life-saving decisions as it determines resource allocation. The way information is produced, shared, and valued can have profound implications for the effectiveness and equity of humanitarian work. This clear misalignment between demands and practices could be leading to epistemological disenfranchisement, where the value of IKM is marginalized in favor of metrics that are more easily quantifiable and aligned with Global North institutions' efforts to standardize and "professionalize" (Escobar, 1995) the humanitarian sector.

5.1 Final Conclusions

5.2 Constraints and Limitations

5.3 Recommendations

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A Interview Guide

A.1 Background Questions

A.2 Core Theme Questions

B Guidelines

C Yet Another Appendix

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C.1 Heading Level 1

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C.2 Heading Level 2

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